

speeches and unreasonable demands have today helped him attain iconic status—proven by Jet Airways employees' rallying behind him after their sacking.

Since February, there have been at least half-a-dozen incidents where his partymen have destroyed property, spread terror and resorted to violence on the streets to create a fear psychosis in the state. His rants against non-Marathis in February this year suited politicians of all hues who are extending him tacit support. Says Abu Asim Azmi, Samajwadi Party MP: "Sharad Pawar and senior Maharashtra IAS officers are advising and supporting Raj Thackeray. Pawar is the one who is instigating him."

Over 30 years ago, the Shiv Sena gained currency when it got the backing of the Congress to counter the communists. If the sluggishness that the state home ministry and the chief minister have shown in handling the MNS eruptions is any indication, history is repeating itself. In February, he was charged with promoting enmity between regional groups through his provocative statements, but his arrest and subsequent release within hours, even as parts of the state continued to burn, was on the condition that he could not make provocative speeches. He has not kept his word and continued to spew venom against north Indians at public rallies. His party workers have beaten up cabbies and damaged shops that did not have signages in Marathi.

All through this, the state machinery has been a silent spectator. Last month, Justice J.N. Patel and Justice K.K. Tated chided the Maharashtra Government for not taking adequate action against Raj after traders protested over MNS violence against shopkeepers on the issue of signages. "Priority for sons-of-the soil is a sentimental issue for a section of the Maharashtrian society. The government handled the situation politically since it didn't want to hurt any community but Raj was not willing to mend his ways," explains Congress leader Sanjay Nirupam. Evidently the 11 crore-

HISTORY OF HATE



HOUNDED: The Bachchans were among the early targets of Raj's fury

- December 2005: Raj falls out with Bal Thackeray; quits Shiv Sena.
- March 2006: Launches Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS).
- February 2008: MNS attacks a Samajwadi Party rally in Mumbai; targets north Indian taxi drivers; drives out Bihari construction workers.
- August 2008: Forces shop owners to display signages in Marathi along with English. Traders protest.
- September 2008: Attacks Jaya Bachchan for speaking in Hindi.
- October 2008: Forcibly close down Jet Airways counters; MNS workers disrupt railway exams and beat up north Indian candidates.



MAXIMUM CITY: Bihari workers hold placards saying Maharashtra belongs to all

strong Marathi population in the state is a big enough votebank that the ruling Congress-Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) cannot do without.

Raj's arrest on Tuesday became inevitable, however, with pressure mounting on the State Government from the Centre over the outbreak of violence at the exam centres of the Railway Recruitment Board on Sunday. As pressure began to build in Parliament, the state government was left with little choice but to arrest him. Says K.L. Prasad, Joint Commissioner (law and order): "The immediate trigger for Raj Thackeray's arrest is the violence that broke out at the Railway Recruitment Board exam centres on Sunday. After spending a night in lock-up, Raj was granted bail by the Kalyan Sessions Court till October 24."

Hours before he was to be presented in court, MNS workers congregated outside the Bandra court and started to pelt stones, damaging vehicles and forcing shops to down shutters across the city. Daily life was disrupted in Mumbai, Nashik, Kolhapur and Pune. Says MNS vice president G.M. Mahale: "The state government is taking action against us only to please their political bosses in Delhi."

What makes Raj interesting is that despite the fact that everyone dismisses him off as an unknown commodity, he has so far managed to walk away scot-free. Senior officials in the government believe that Raj is a smart politician who is trying to sway the uneducated lot—both within and outside the police—on grounds of language and culture. He has

carved a niche for himself by pretending to be the messiah of the *aam aadmi*. Given that the Congress-NCP combine is on the backfoot, thanks to the sorry state of governance in the state, it makes great sense to encourage a breakaway faction of the Shiv Sena with an eye on splitting the Marathi vote. For short-term gains, the Maharashtra Government and the chief minister have reared a Frankenstein. The damage these policies inflict are likely to last much longer.

with Swati Mathur